



The final scene of *La Dolce Vita* contains a second allusion. The fisherman who hauls the ray out of the sea says the bloated, rotting leviathan has been dead “for three days.” In the Bible, this is the same period of time that Jesus spends in the tomb. *La Dolce Vita* is a carnival of Roman Catholic imagery and symbols, much of it controversial in its use. The opening sequence, in which a golden statue of Christ flies over an ancient Roman aqueduct,

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In sum, it is an awesome picture, licentious in content but moral and vastly sophisticated in its attitude and what it says.

Bosley Crowther
New York Times, 1960

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Marcello is repeatedly drawn to Maddalena (Anouk Aimée), but his love for her cannot lead anywhere. She asks him to marry her, only to fall into the arms of another man moments later.

dangling benignly from a helicopter with Marcello following it in a second helicopter, caused outrage when the movie was first screened.

Although two Christ figures (the statue and the manta ray) bookend the narrative, they fail to offer hope or salvation to any of its characters. In fact, Fellini constantly connects religious myth with disillusionment. Marcello is looking for his Eve, the first woman on the first day of Creation, an angelic figure untainted by the corruptions of *la dolce vita* or any earthly experience. “I don’t believe in your aggressive, sticky, maternal love!” he tells Emma during their endlessly recurring fight. “This isn’t love,” he screams at her, “it’s brutalization!” And so whenever he dives back into the chaos of the Roman night, he knows that Eve doesn’t really exist; all he is doing is trying to forget what he knows. ■



Marcello Mastroianni

Actor

Following a brief period of theater work, Marcello Mastroianni became famous with a role in *Big Deal on Madonna Street*. He was Fellini’s only choice for the role of Marcello Rubini in *La Dolce Vita*. The studio had wanted Paul Newman, but Fellini fought to keep his friend, and the pair went on to make six more movies together. Mastroianni often played a version of the director in these movies.

A suave and darkly handsome figure, Mastroianni became closely associated with the glamour of Rome and its beautiful leading ladies, especially Sophia Loren (who shared the screen with him in 11 movies). He earned two Academy Award nominations during his career, one for the comedy *Divorce Italian Style* in 1961 and the other for *A Special Day* in 1977.

Key movies

1958 *Big Deal on Madonna Street*
1960 *La Dolce Vita*
1961 *Divorce Italian Style*
1963 *8½*